

APRIL

EUROPE

Eel Day, Ely, UK

Ellie the Eel, a giant replica of the slippery fish that gave this Fenland city its name, leads a colorful procession from the 7th-century cathedral to the Jubilee Gardens, where everyone joins in the eel-tasting, beer-swilling, hog-roasting, and medieval jollity. There's even an eel-throwing contest – though these days they use socks!

Fiestas del Bollo, Avilés, Spain

On Easter Monday, Avilés' historic downtown pulsates with traditional music, decorated floats, folk dancers, and throngs of people in vivid costumes. Rows of tables, hundreds of place-settings long, are covered with a communal feast of mouthwatering Asturian dishes, the focus of which is the *bollo*, a multi-tiered, star-shaped extravaganza of an iced bun.

Fête de la Coquille, Côtes d'Armor, France

Three ancient fishing ports on the Côtes d'Armor take turns to host this celebration of the scallop. Up to 80,000 seafood-lovers come to see the boats unload their day's catch, watch the waterside auctions, and sample Brittany's legendary *coquilles St-Jacques* against a background of Celtic music.

THE MIDDLE EAST AND AFRICA

Ikeji, Arondizuogu, Nigeria

Ikeji isn't just a yam festival, it's a centuries-old veneration of the Aro tribal culture. The yam isn't just a vegetable, either: it is revered as the very essence of the Aro economy and way of life. As revelers enjoy a sumptuous feast, masked gods dance among them, dispelling evil spirits to the delirious rhythms of traditional drums, bells, and flutes.

Prince Albert Olive Festival, South Africa

High in the Swartbergs in the Western Cape, on the edge of the Great Karoo, the climate is perfect for growing olives. Village farms offer tastings of fresh and marinated olives and their oils, Karoo lamb stews, award-winning cheeses, and delicious local wines. Fire-dancers, folk music, fun runs, stargazing, ghost walks, and even a pit-spitting contest make this a great family experience. www.patourism.co.za



ASIA AND AUSTRALASIA

Hanshi, Xiamen, China

This festival dates to 2,500 years ago, when, once a year, cooking fires were extinguished and allowed to rest before relighting with new-season firewood. The custom is honored with cold food feasts of rice porridge, pickled vegetables, fish paste, bamboo shoots, tofu, date cakes, and preserved eggs.

World Gourmet Summit, Singapore

Singapore is always a gastronomic paradise, but never more so than in April, when some of the world's most renowned chefs come together to share their secrets with eager gourmets. Events include culinary masterclasses, intimate Chef's Table dinners, tutored tastings, and in-depth workshops. Every serious foodie should make the pilgrimage at least once. www.worldgourmetsummit.com

NORTH AMERICA

World Grits Festival, St. George, South Carolina, USA

It's over 25 years since St. George discovered it was the world's biggest consumer of grits – a dish made of coarsely ground corn – and the town hasn't stopped celebrating yet. Tens of thousands join in the fun and games – tossing corn cobs, rolling in vats of gooey grits, and chowing down in an all-you-can-eat contest.

Oistins Fish Festival, Barbados

Beautiful Barbados honors its fishermen and celebrates the spectacular harvest of its waters at this Easter event. Visitors can choose from a vast array of seafood and dine in the sunshine or under the stars to a calypso beat. If that's too laid-back, games and competitions include a fish-boning challenge and even a greasy pole contest.

Le Pince d'Or, Grand'Rivière, near Fort-de-France, Martinique

The tiny fishing village of Grand'Rivière brings together the island's French and Caribbean flavors in its Pince d'Or (Golden Pincer) competition, held each Easter Sunday. The aim is to cook the best *matoutou*, a rich crab stew flavored with lime, cinnamon, chili pepper, and garlic. Join the locals along the palm-fringed riverside for a day of feasting and music.

MAY

EUROPE

Spargelfest, Schwetzingen, Germany

Historic Schwetzingen is Europe's white asparagus capital. At the spring harvest festival, this "Royal Vegetable" is sold in the castle square, fresh or cooked in many different recipes. A favorite is with hollandaise sauce and smoked ham, but there's even asparagus ice cream. There are colorful parades, banquets, and the triumphant crowning of the festival's Asparagus King or Queen.

Fête des Fromages, Rocamadour, France

One of the most beautiful villages in France hosts the largest cheese festival in the south. It begins with a blessing of the herds of sheep and goats, which are then paraded through the streets, and continues with an outdoor festive lunch, a farmers' market, and performances of traditional regional music. Be sure to try Rocamadour's own esteemed Cabécou goat cheese. <http://fromages.rocamadour.free.fr>

Watercress Festival, Alresford, UK

Mineral-rich spring water is the secret behind Alresford's success as the UK's largest producer of this versatile and delectable superfood. The Watercress King and Queen lead a parade of jazz bands and morris dancers, handing out the new season's watercress to thousands of revelers. There's a huge street market, cooking demonstrations from celebrity chefs, and the World Watercress Eating Championship. www.watercressfestival.org

European Beer Festival, Copenhagen, Denmark

The best beer festival in the world? Who knows, but brewing giant Carlsberg opens its historic cellars and stables to host this intoxicating extravaganza that offers visitors the opportunity to taste hundreds of Danish and international beers, ales, and lagers. The festival is hosted in various venues across the city. Book events early to avoid disappointment.

